

Two new weights / *Deux nouveaux poids*

There is a story about a man who went into a bar. He told the bartender, “Give me a free beer or I’ll drink the contents of this spittoon.” The bartender told him, “Don’t nobody get free beers around here!” So the man proceeded to start drinking it. Customers saw him and began looking violently ill. After a moment, the bartender said, “Okay, the customers are going to lose their lunches! You can have a free beer!” The man kept drinking. “All right, two beers!” Still he drank. “Three! Four! Stop!” Finally, the man tilted the spittoon upside down and drank the last of it. “Why did you drink the whole thing?! I said I’d give you the free beer!” the bartender asked. The man replied with a sorrowful look, “It was all in one string.”

I know this story I’m writing is pretty corny, but I’m going to continue it, because I’m like that man. So here goes.

I ran around it to the streambank and then directly into the stream. I started swimming across to put some distance between that thing and me, but halfway to the middle, I got severely uncomfortable knowing that I had no idea what kind of animals were swimming underneath me. I paddled right back to the bank. It’s better, I figured, to be able to see what’s going to try to eat me, isn’t it? I edgily walked along the bank, keeping a constant watch on all sides of me. Nothing peered out from the forest, but that didn’t calm me at all. I was understandably way beyond becoming calm. I was sure I saw shining red eyes staring at me, thinking, “filets.” I kept up a brisk and nervous pace. I was shaking all over. Deep breaths didn’t help. I tried imagining I was back at home in the nice 2007 creekbed, which would have maybe a few small fish in the water and some cute lizards on the banks, maybe a snake or two, no primitive amphibian crocodiles contemplating which ones of their two hundred teeth they could sink into me for optimal palatal pleasure. But as soon as I took my attention off the present, such as it was, and thought about my own time, off to my side there was a ripple in the water from something surfacing, and I immediately realized

how bad an idea that was. Calming, but dangerous; and I doubled my darting glances and the speed of my nervous shuffle.

How far down the stream had I floated? From effects inside and outside itself, my mind was racing. Which way do I go to get home? That was the primary question. But bounce around as it might inside my head, it didn’t get anywhere closer to resolving itself. There was nothing to build off of. I had fallen off a waterfall and caromed off several rocks and ended up in the Mesozoic, or the Palaeocene, or the Mediterranean, or some long geological term. What was I supposed to make of that? All I could think of was what I had thought of in the first moment after I saw something no human should ever see staring me down, that thought being that I needed to retrace my steps. And I was already doing that. Doing all I could do. Something giant burst out of the water.

I only saw it for a split second, because instantly after it appeared I was running for all I was worth in the opposite direction. From what I saw it was orange and looked like something out of the nightmares of a deranged person after a tour through a slaughtering plant. I plunged into the forest and ran until I felt my lungs collapsing. Then, with a panicked look behind, I fell over and lay on the ground. This was not going to be a quickly resolved problem. For one thing, I had now gotten myself lost again. Amazing how I managed to do this so consistently when it was the worst possible thing to do –first, closing my eyes while playing pinball, and now this. Presence of mind wasn’t my strong suit, I realized, but too late to do anything about it.

And of course, updated character sets and pangrams.

NEWT BOLD (This weight formerly known as bold has been renamed “demi”)
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